

Start From This Line

DIFFICULT PRACTICE



Name: _____

Date set: _____

Due: _____

YOUR OPENING LINE — USE IT EXACTLY, WORD FOR WORD, AS THE FIRST LINE OF YOUR STORY

“By the time anyone thought to ask, it was already too late to matter.”

Unlike “continue the story,” you are building everything after this line yourself — including who “anyone” is, what they should have asked, and why it’s too late. This line can open a story in almost any genre. Choose one direction and commit to it fully rather than trying to keep several possibilities open.

TECHNIQUE REQUIRED

USING THE GIVEN LINE

The line must genuinely set up what follows — by the end, a reader should be able to look back and see exactly what “it” and “too late” referred to.

Do not explain the line directly in your second sentence (“It was too late because...”). Let the meaning unfold through the story instead.

VOICE & TENSE

The given line is past tense, third person — decide immediately whether you’re staying in that voice throughout or shifting deliberately, and be consistent.

At least one moment where the narration hints at foreknowledge (the narrator already knows how this ends) without giving the ending away.

STRUCTURE

Build toward a clear turning point — the moment “anyone” should have asked, or did ask too late.

End the piece by circling back to the idea of “too late” in a way that feels earned, not repeated word-for-word.

LANGUAGE

At least 2 pieces of figurative language that fit the tone you’ve chosen (tense thriller, quiet tragedy, dark comedy — your choice).

Vary sentence openings and lengths — avoid three sentences in a row starting the same way.

YOUR WRITING

CHECKLIST – GO OVER IT AGAIN

1. Check your opening line was copied **exactly**, word for word, with correct punctuation.
2. Read the whole piece back – does the ending genuinely justify the ominous opening, or does the story undersell it?
3. Tense and person stay consistent (or any deliberate shift is clearly signalled).
4. No unearned twist – a strong ending should feel inevitable once you know it, not random.
5. Check punctuation around any dialogue and correct use of commas in longer sentences.
6. No word repeated in the same sentence or the one right after it – swap for a synonym.